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| **Fiscal Year:** | FY 2019 | **Task Last Updated:** | FY 10/04/2019 |
| **PI Name:** | Venkateswaran, Kasthuri Ph.D. | | |
| **Project Title:** | Bacterial, Archaeal, & Fungal Diversity of the ISS | | |
| **Division Name:** | Space Biology | | |
| **Program/Discipline:** | SPACE BIOLOGY | | |
| **Program/Discipline--Element/Subdiscipline:** | SPACE BIOLOGY--Cellular and molecular biology | | |
| **Joint Agency Name:** | | **TechPort:** | No |
| **Human Research Program Elements:** | None | | |
| **Human Research Program Risks:** | None | | |
| **Space Biology Element:** | (1) Cell & Molecular Biology<br>(2) Microbiology | | |
| **Space Biology Cross-Element Discipline:** | (1) Reproductive Biology | | |
| **Space Biology Special Category:** | None | | |
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| **PI Organization Type:** | NASA CENTER | **Phone:** | 818-393-1481 |
| **Organization Name:** | NASA Jet Propulsion Laboratory | | |
| **PI Address 1:** | Biotechnology and Planetary Protection | | |
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| **City:** | Pasadena | **State:** | CA |
| **Zip Code:** | 91109-8001 | **Congressional District:** | 27 |
| **Comments:** | | | |
| **Project Type:** | Flight | **Solicitation / Funding Source:** | 2012 Space Biology<br>NNH12ZTT001N |
| **Start Date:** | 07/01/2013 | **End Date:** | 12/31/2020 |
| **No. of Post Docs:** | 3 | **No. of PhD Degrees:** | 1 |
| **No. of PhD Candidates:** | 2 | **No. of Master' Degrees:** | 0 |
| **No. of Master's Candidates:** | | **No. of Bachelor's Degrees:** | 1 |
| **No. of Bachelor's Candidates:** | 4 | **Monitoring Center:** | NASA ARC |
| **Contact Monitor:** | Sato, Kevin | **Contact Phone:** | 650-604-1104 |
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| **Flight Program:** | ISS | | |
| **Flight Assignment:** | NOTE: Title change in May 2015 to "Bacterial, Archaeal, & Fungal Diversity of the ISS--HEPA Filter System" from "Bacterial, Archaeal, & Fungal Diversity of Kibo-JEM Surfaces," per A. Chu/ NASA ARC via NASA JPL Rev. A to Task Order (Ed., 9/24/15)<br>NOTE: End date changed to 12/31/2020 per F. Hernandez/ARC (Ed., 12/6/19)<br>NOTE: Extended to 12/31/2019 and project number changed to 47-700062 under Task Order NNN17D016T per F. Hernandez/ARC (Ed., 12/17/18)<br>NOTE: Extended to 9/30/2018 per F. Hernandez/ARC (Ed., 3/26/18)<br>NOTE: Extended to 3/31/2018 per F. Hernandez/ARC (Ed., 8/31/17)<br>NOTE: Extended to 6/30/2017 per A. Chu/ARC (Ed., 9/17/15) | | |
| **Key Personnel Changes/Previous PI:** | September 2017 report: Parag Vaishampayan in no longer Co-Investigator on this project. | | |
| **COI Name (Institution):** | | | |
| **Grant/Contract No.:** | 47-700062 under Task Order NNN17D016T ; 19-12829-27 under Task Order NNN13D111T | | |

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| **Performance Goal No.:** | |
| **Performance Goal Text:** | |
| **Task Description:** | May 2015 Revision to Task Agreement (Ed. note: information received September 2015).<br>Due to problems obtaining samples from Kibo-JEM (Japanese Experiment Module), the project has been modified with a new title, “Bacterial, Archaeal, & Fungal Diversity of the ISS--HEPA Filter System.” The revised scope will allow the Jet Propulsion Laboratory (JPL) to undertake a 28-month flight study to examine the microorganisms associated with HEPA filters. The ISS-HEPA project will develop a comprehensive census of the microbial population on the HEPA filter collected from various locations of the International Space Station (ISS), using genetic biosignatures and computational modeling. This microbial census will provide NASA with the ability to accurately and confidently assess the status of microbes associated with closed habitation and crew health maintenance. In addition to overall microbial profiles, the JPL team will determine which microbial taxa pose particular threats to crew health.<br><br>Original Task Description: Space microbiology research working groups in Japan, authorized by the Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency (JAXA), submitted proposals in response to the JAXA Announcement of Opportunity, 2012. The JAXA proposal that is managed by Principal Investigator Prof. Masao Nasu, Osaka University, contained several subgroups, including subgroup 4, headed by Dr. Takashi Yamazaki, JAXA. This subgroup 4 will conduct an investigation on “Analysis of microbial dynamics in the space habitation system by using new molecular microbial ecological techniques and also monitoring microbial contamination from air and surfaces of the ‘Kibo’ Japanese Experiment Module (Kibo-JEM).” The JAXA proposal submitted by subgroup 4 identifies the Jet Propulsion Laboratory (JPL) team headed by Dr. Kasthuri Venkateswaran as a collaborator to jointly explore the investigation.<br><br>The Bacterial, Archaeal, and Fungal Diversity of Kibo-JEM Surfaces project (JPL-JAXA project) will undertake a three-year flight study to examine the changes in the microorganism population on the Kibo-JEM surfaces. The JPL-JAXA project proposes to develop a comprehensive census of the microbial population on the Kibo-JEM surfaces, using genetic biosignatures and computational modeling. This census will provide NASA and JAXA with the ability to accurately and confidently assess the status of microbes associated with closed habitation and crew health maintenance. In addition to overall microbial profiles, the JPL-JAXA team will determine which microbial taxa pose particular threats to crew health. Specific JPL-JAXA project goals will enable us to resolve applicable Human Research Program (HRP) integrated research plan (IRP) risks: (1) determine if changes in Kibo-JEM microbiome are occurring during a spaceflight mission and if so, (2) determine whether any changes noted would create a greater health risk for the crew.<br><br>There are three aims proposed in this JPL-JAXA project and study of the Kibo-JEM microbiome. Through optimizations and comparative evaluations of methods designed to collect, process, analyze, and archive biomolecules sampled, the JPL-JAXA team will increase downstream sensitivity of laboratory assays as well as enhance the current understanding of the population dynamics of the Kibo-JEM module (Aim 1). The JPL-JAXA team will adapt molecular technologies currently in use with the National Institute of Health (NIH) – Human Microbiome Program (HMP) Roadmap—such as rRNA gene-variable region tag sequencing, whole genome shotgun sequencing (WGS), and DNA microarrays, as well as cloning and sequencing of 16S ribosomal DNA (rDNA)—to comprehensively elucidate the microbial diversity profiles associated with the Kibo-JEM surfaces (Aim 2). The final project deliverable to NASA will be the Kibo-JEM database, a compilation of all of the genomic sequences and genetic information of microbes encountered on and within the Kibo-JEM habitat (Aim 3). Computational modeling of the Kibo-JEM microbial population dynamics inferred from the database will then be carried out to predict the complete spectrum of organisms present.<br><br>The JPL-JAXA project will compare microbial diversity, microbial characteristics, and functional capabilities of the microorganisms associated with the Kibo-JEM. The resulting database will enable HRP to evaluate the effect of spaceflight radiation and microgravity on the Kibo-JEM microbiome. The JPL-JAXA project in combination with results from studies of crew susceptibility will be used to determine the risk of microbiologically induced adverse health effects during a spaceflight mission. This assessment will allow HRP to determine if current operational and engineering controls used to mitigate microbiological risks are adequate or whether additional countermeasures should be developed. |
| **Rationale for HRP Directed Research:** | |
| **Research Impact/Earth Benefits:** | The JPL-JAXA project proposes to develop a comprehensive census of the microbial population on the Kibo-JEM surfaces, using genetic biosignatures and computational modeling. This microbial census will provide NASA and JAXA with the ability to accurately and confidently assess the status of microbes associated with closed habitation and crew health maintenance. In addition to overall microbial profiles, the JPL-JAXA team will determine which microbial taxa pose particular threats to crew health. |
| **Task Progress:** | Samples received from JAXA and the ISS were processed for the cultivable counts, molecular burden analyses using qPCR. The samples received were dust particles and also several new ISS HEPA filters were included.<br>The extracted DNA were quantified for both bacterial (16SrRNA gene) and fungal (ITS region) burden. Subsequently, the DNA were subjected to shotgun metagenomics for microbial diversity analyses.<br><br>In the remaining task period, we will be analyzing the shotgun metagenomics sequence data for functional analyses and compared with the ISS HEPA filters. |
| **Bibliography Type:** | Description: (Last Updated: 03/31/2026) |
| **Articles in Peer-reviewed Journals** | Blachowicz A, Chiang AJ, Romsdahl J, Kalkum M, Wang CCC, Venkateswaran K. "Proteomic characterization of Aspergillus fumigatus isolated from air and surfaces of the International Space Station." Fungal Genet Biol. 2019 Mar;124:39-46. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.fgb.2019.01.001 ; PubMed PMID: 30611835 , Mar-2019 |